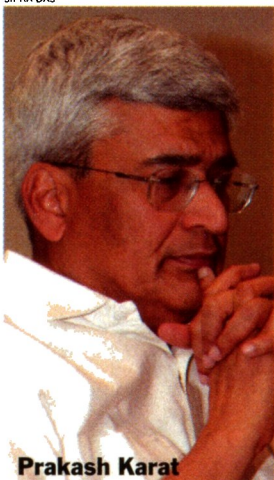


SIPRA DAS

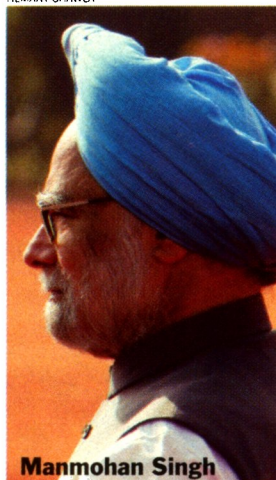


Prakash Karat

THE RED RAGE

It's easy to see why Sonia Gandhi kept to herself the portfolio of allies-management rather than outsource it to the PMO. Singh created a crisis for himself when he dared Karat to back the nuclear deal or withdraw support. His 'so be it' threat made Karat see red. Buttered dosas for breakfast at the PM's failed to appease Karat who stepped up opposition to the deal, while Manmohan is yet to make up his mind. Breakfast bonhomie has now given way to coordination committees. The time is running out for a patchup.

HEMANT CHAWLA



Manmohan Singh



THE BARBS

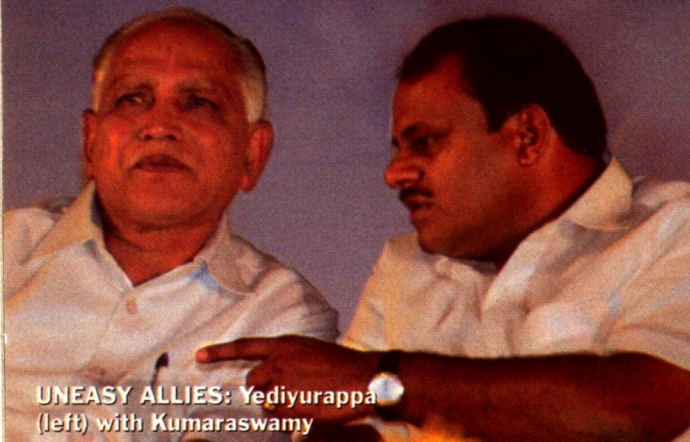
We can't go back on the deal. If they (CPI-M) walk out, so be it.

MANMOHAN SINGH,
AUGUST 11

GIREESH GV

SOUTHERN DISCOMFORT

It was more of a mesalliance than an alliance. In October, when H.D. Kumaraswamy reneged on his promise to give up the chief minister's chair and support B.S. Yediyurappa, all the BJP ministers resigned to step up the pressure. At first, Kumaraswamy sulked and scouted in vain for Congress support. Finally, he agreed to support BJP, but withdrew it less than a week after Yediyurappa took oath as chief minister. The BJP man now plans to make the great betrayal his main poll plank.



UNEASY ALLIES: Yediyurappa (left) with Kumaraswamy

HEARTLAND HEAT

This is not politics, it's personal. Among the last decisions that Mulayam took as chief minister was to sanction a CBI probe in the Taj Corridor case against Mayawati. She took over saying "I won't attack someone who is already dead." But went on to do precisely that. She has since reversed every major decision taken by Mulayam including a Reliance mega project, the flagship U.P. Development Council and the appointment of 11,000 police personnel.

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



Mayawati

SIPRA DAS



Mulayam Yadav

It is for the prime minister to decide if he wants to run the government.

PRAKASH KARAT,
AUGUST 12

Those who administer Gujarat do so as merchants of fear and death.

SONIA GANDHI,
DECEMBER 1

Congress is trying to save terrorists like Afzal Guru. That shows who are with the merchants of death.

NARENDRA MODI
DECEMBER 2

THE PRODIGAL NEPHEW

HK RAJASHEKAR



He went from being the DMK leader's favourite nephew to an outcast in the flash of a day's headline. An opinion poll carried by Maran's paper that pitted Karunanidhi's two sons against each other riled the DMK chief enough to show him the cabinet door. If Maran's rise was swift, his fall was even faster.

Maran (left) and Karunanidhi

HK RAJASHEKAR

